ask. If I'd been another kind of character, I'd have gone off anyway and then blamed traffic for me being fifteen minutes late getting to work. I'm not the only dad in the world who'd be desperate to be at his son's nursery school for something like that and I hoped the boss would understand. At worst, I thought, he might just say no; that we had a big game and he didn't want me to go. But he was furious:

'Hell, David, what are you after? What more do you want?'

Before I could say anything he just turned on his heel and walked away. I had to take that as my answer. I was sorry to miss Brooklyn's play but I understood a manager not wanting his player to be there on the day of a game. What I didn't understand was why it was such a big deal that I'd asked.

This standoff just seemed to drag on. They were the worst three months I'd ever had at Old Trafford. The boss, when he wasn't having a go at me, seemed to be ignoring me. I got more and more depressed. At training, at home, I felt like just withdrawing into my shell. I'd be really quiet. Things people said to me would go in one ear and out the other. He was ignoring me and I found myself ignoring him and pretty well everything else, too. Obviously I talked to Gary, to Victoria, and to Tony Stephens about what was going on. But I really missed there being someone at the club to act as an intermediary between me and the boss: a Brian Kidd, a Steve McClaren or an Eric Harrison who could see things from the manager's perspective as well as the players', who really understood what the situation was and could advise you accordingly. The new number two, Carlos Queiroz, was a great coach, no question, but maybe because of a language barrier or because of his own background as a top-flight manager himself, he wasn't someone I'd have felt comfortable having that kind of conversation with. I don't think Carlos would have recognized it as part of his job, either. The boss himself, obviously, didn't want to talk to me. For the first time in my United career, I felt like I didn't have anybody on the staff I could turn to for help.

I've already mentioned how difficult I've found it to cope with my parents' splitting up. It goes without saying, though, that with the situation between them coming to a head and, then, the divorce going through, my own relationship with Mum and Dad couldn't help but be affected too. Any son, or daughter, who's lived through a family breaking up, will know how disorientating and confusing it is. With Dad, especially, things changed over that time. In the past, he'd have been the first person I'd have talked to about what was happening at Old Trafford. Now, he had his own problems and pressures to deal with and it didn't feel right to be looking to him for advice.